of existential threats or the Holocaust, no rhetorical bombast. He had talked about gay marriage, solar energy and making it easier to get a mortgage.

The Palestinians had been courted, albeit skeptically. “I do not know what kind of mood I will be faced with from the Palestinian leadership, because they have fallen in love with unilateralism, but I believe Livni and I are the only ones who can rally the international community behind us,” he had told prospective voters in Tel Aviv. He had even offered an olive branch to the Jewish diaspora, which had found supporting Israel increasingly troublesome in recent years. “The impact on the Jewish community is not discussed enough in the corridors and halls of power in Israel. I think it should be taken into account,” he had promised.

He had also spent much of the campaign trying to reclaim “Zionism” from the right—rejecting their exceptionalist, messianic view, and portraying Israel as a sort of Switzerland on the Mediterranean.

The problem for Herzog, of course, is that it is not. It is a country with no fixed borders; it has nonexistent relations with many of its neighbors, and a seemingly permanent domination over another people. It is slowly becoming a pariah in the West. The “peace camp” is a shell of its former self; poll after poll shows that younger Israelis hold more hawkish and nationalist views than their parents. Herzog lost, but even if he had won, it seems doubtful that he could have addressed these issues. “The fear is that he will dilute his views, blur his views, to act like a prime minister for all Israelis, and this will lead to a further deterioration in the legitimacy of the political system,” Hermann said before the vote. “People will feel betrayed, especially those who crossed the lines.”

Almost everyone agreed that tossing out King Bibi would have been a breath of fresh air. Two days before the election, atop a Vietnamese restaurant on Rothschild Boulevard, the offices of V15 were buzzing. It was a grassroots organization, born in December of 2014 with a single Facebook post, that went on to recruit tens of thousands of volunteers to mount the largest get-out-the-vote operation in Israeli history. Campaigners had knocked on more than 150,000 doors before the vote, urging voters to change the government, and returned to each one on election day.

“He’s done nothing on the economy, he ignores the Palestinians, he tells us there’s no solution to Gaza, that we just have to accept another war every two years,” said Nimrod Dweck—one of the co-founders—of Netanyahu.